Institution: Rhode Island School of Design Museum
Registration Number: 26.166
Fabric: South Italian; Earthenware
Shape: Rhyton (drinking cup)
Attribution: N/A
Place of Manufacture: Taras (Tarentum), Apulia, Magna Graecia
Date: After 350BCE
Dimensions: H. 17.8cm
Provenance: RISD Museum appropriation fund

Fabric, Technique, Shape & Condition South Italian earthenware rhyton with a bull head body, likely made by press-moulding. Wheel-thrown neck. The surface is slipped and slip-painted. Black glaze is largely intact with rubbing at the crown of the bull's head and at the base. No pouring aperture is present at the muzzle.

Iconography The vessel takes the form of a bull's head, with a flaring wheel-thrown neck rising from the moulded body. The neck carries a red-figure decorative programme: a nude satyr, tailed and wreathed, holding a thyrsos in his left and a tympanum(?) in his right (Fig. 1). He strides to the right between flanking scroll ornaments. The tail, thyrsos, and tympanum together confirm the Dionysiac identity of the figure. The combination finds direct parallels on the neck of a bull-head rhyton associated with the Iliupersis Painter in the J. Paul Getty Museum (Fig. 2), where a comparable (but female) dancer with tympanum decorates a vessel of the same class and approximate production context.[1] A tongue pattern runs around the interior of the rim. The bull's head is rendered with modelled relief detail: curling forelocks between the horn stubs, shallow circular eyes, and outward-flaring ears at the join of the neck and body.

Fig. 1. *Drinking Cup (Rhyton)*, after 350 BCE. Earthenware, slip-painted. Rhode Island School of Design Museum, Providence, 26.166. Image © RISD Museum.

Standard functional rhyta of the bull-head type have a small aperture at the muzzle (the animal's nose or mouth) through which liquid flows when filled through the wide opening at the top. This use is consistent with the name of the vessel shape, deriving from the Greek *rheo*, which means to flow. On this vessel, no secondary opening is present. The absence of a pouring aperture at the muzzle is a feature sometimes cited as an indicator of funerary intent, though the argument is not conclusive. Research shows that majority of Tarentine rhyta are unpierced, and that there is no convincing evidence this implies any ritual or apotropaic function.[2] The funerary character of this vessel rests more securely on a convergence of other evidence, such as the Tarentine production context, in which animal-head rhyta were used not as actual drinking vessels but as a part of the funerary mobilier,[3] and the

[1] Holo, Selma. "Unpublished Apulian Rhyta." J. Paul Getty Museum Journal 1 (1974): 88, figs. 6–8, 12. The Getty bull-head rhyton (71.AE.196) is described as decorated with "a dancing maenad holding a tympanum."

[2] Richter, Gisela M. A. Review of Herbert Hoffmann, *Attic Red-Figured Rhyta* (Mainz, 1962). *Revue belge de philologie et d'histoire* 41, no. 2 (1963): 515.

[3] Holo 1974, 85.

Dionysiac iconographic programme, which in Apulian funerary ceramics consistently invokes the chthonic rather than the convivial aspect of the god.[4] The choice of the bull as the body of this vessel carries deliberate significance in a funerary setting. At Tarentum and across the broader Apulian world, Dionysus was venerated in bovine form as simultaneously the god of wine and the presiding deity of the underworld.[5]

Fig. 2. *Apulian Bull Head Rhyton*, c. 360 BCE. Terracotta. J. Paul Getty Museum, Malibu, 71.AE.196. Associated with the Iliupersis Painter. Image © J. Paul Getty Museum (Open Access)

The form of this vessel therefore activates a double register: as a vessel formally associated with the pouring of libations and as a plastic embodiment of the chthonic Dionysus to whom those libations were directed in the grave. The satyr on the neck reinforces this reading. As a member of the Dionysiac thiasos, his presence marks the deity's domain and participates in the iconographic language of Dionysiac afterlife belief that pervades Apulian funerary ceramics of this period.[6]

Attribution & Dating No individual attribution is possible. The vessel belongs to the class of animal-head rhyta produced in Taras (modern-day Taranto), likely in the later fourth century BCE. Attic workshops had exported red-figure plastic vases, including rhyta, to Southern Italian markets from the fifth century BCE, but Attic production of the shape largely ceased towards the end of the century. Tarentine potters subsequently developed their own production of animal-head rhyta to satisfy local demand. This is reflected in the surviving body of work, as the majority of Tarentine rhyta derive from grave contexts. A date after 350BCE places the vessel in the later phase of local production in Magna Graecia, contemporaneous with the major late Apulian workshops including the circle of the Darius Painter.

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5 Holo 1974, 85–94;

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Works Cited

Holo, Selma. "Unpublished Apulian Rhyta." *J. Paul Getty Museum Journal* 1 (1974): 85–94. https://www.jstor.org/stable/4166318

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Trendall, A.D. *Red Figure Vases of South Italy and Sicily*. London: Thames and Hudson, 1966.